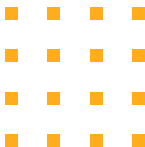
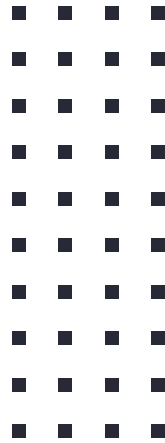




Acknowledging The Barriers Returning Citizens Face

By Wilson A MacPherson



Purpose:

The purpose of this presentation is to understand the barriers that returning citizens face in order to begin brainstorming possible solutions for these problems. These problems stem from what I have gathered through interviews with returned citizens and cover a wide scope of issues. I recognize it will be difficult to address all these issues simultaneously, so additionally, a purpose for this presentation is prioritizing what issues can feasibly be addressed.

1) Lack Of Network

- Returning citizens greatest barrier for seamless re-entry
- A lack of network is a double sided issue
 - It makes it easier to fall back into a crowd of troublemakers, and make the same mistakes that landed you in jail
 - It makes it difficult to find legitimate employment

2) First Week (or Two) Are Most Dangerous

- Danger comes from lack of network, but this issue is multifaceted
 - Proper resources to live independently such as food, water and lodging
 - Improper attire to seek employment
 - Lack of regimented lifestyle brings a high chance to be self destructive



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“The recidivism rate in the first year out is, what like 50% right? (its 44%). I bet 90% of that statistic is in the first two weeks. I knew so many guys who came back fast”

— Kevin



4) Credit Score

- When you go to prison, regardless if you are convicted of a felony, your credit score takes a hit because payments freeze.
 - This happens even if people are willing to make your payments for you
- Alternative credit scores are a solution to this such as the R3 score, but these solutions do not carry the same weight as a regular Fico score

5) Inability to Bank Effectively

- Banks freeze your account when you go prison and will not let make any payments. This affects your credit score
- Also, due to general financial illiteracy, many returning citizens don't trust banks and end up hurting their chances at long term financial security
 - Additionally, financial illiteracy puts them at at a heightened risk for dangerous financial “solutions” (bad loans, poor wealth management, ect.)

6) Felony Charges Make Some Things Impossible

- You cannot get a small business loan if you have a felony charge
 - This makes startup costs for well intentioned entrepreneurship impossible
- Also you cannot get student loans if you have a felony charge, so if someone chooses this route for a better life, they are a massive step behind

7) Punitive Probation

- Probation offices are only open during regular business hours
 - This means a person has to take off work to meet with their probation officer
- Self employment is unacceptable to meet the work requirement for probation



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“Bro they wanna see you back in that cage, and if they don't, then they sure do a bad job of showing it”

— Rob

“I would have made more money; more money to actually help get back on my feet faster, if they had let me work for myself full time instead of a low paying part time job. I would've worked under any supervision necessary to make it happen”



— Kevin



8) Life Insurance

- Life insurance is especially hard to acquire as a returning citizen
- Unfortunately, this makes sense due to a high suicide rate and a heightened likelihood for risky behavior
- Car insurance seems to be unaffected though, and I was unable to gather information on other types of insurance.



A Possible Solution: Stipend Apprenticeship



Advocacy

- A partnership with local business and groups who are already working with returning citizens (such as Capital Impact Partners), FinMango may be able to help create an apprenticeship program that benefits returning citizens in a unique way



3 Parts Of Suggested Program

Apprenticeship

- By partnering with local business, government and volunteers, we can allow returning citizens to build professional skills and a network before returning into the working world, by giving incentives to employers to teach them professional skills

Financial Literacy: FinMango

- FinMango does what it does best: teach about financial literacy and help returning citizens have their best chance at long lasting financial security.
- FinMango could also use it's connections to get interesting keynote speakers to increase the enrollment of the program

Aid and Continued Support

- Upon Graduation from the program and release, they receive a care package of basic necessities
 - Professional Attire, Food, Water, ect.
- We also give them volunteers email so they can check in if they need to

Acknowledgements:

- This plan is going to take a lot of resources and a ton of volunteer effort to fall into place
- This plan still needs fine tuning to address as many re-entry-barrier-issues as possible
- Specifics on such a plan were not addressed
- This is a very rough outline, and is only a start. Suggestions are very much appreciated.